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Phinehas

The zealous priest who stopped a plague and was given a covenant of peace.

Phinehas, son of Eleazar and grandson of Aaron, stepped onto the stage at one of the darkest moments of the wilderness years. On the plains of Moab many Israelites joined the women of Moab and Midian in immorality and in worship of Baal-peor, and a plague broke out. While the people wept at the tabernacle door, an Israelite leader brought a Midianite woman into his tent. Phinehas killed them both, and the plague stopped. God gave him "my covenant of peace." Later he served as a peacemaker between the tribes and as high priest.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Pinchas</i> , probably from an Egyptian name meaning "the Nubian"
Family	Son of Eleazar; grandson of Aaron; his mother was a daughter of Putiel (Exodus 6:25)
Role	Priest, and later high priest (Numbers 25:11–13; Judges 20:28)
When	c. 1406 BC at Peor (early date), into the judges' time
Key places	The plains of Moab, Shiloh, the Jordan River, Bethel
Not the same as	Phinehas son of Eli (1 Samuel 1:3; 4:11)
Main passages	Numbers 25:1–18; 31:6; Joshua 22:10–34
New Testament	Not named

"Then stood up Phinehas, and executed judgment: and so the plague was stayed."

Psalm 106:30, KJV

The life of Phinehas

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, with Israel on the plains of Moab c. 1406 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. Joshua 22 and Judges 20 are not dated.

Family	Born to Eleazar Eleazar, Aaron's son, marries one of the daughters of Putiel, and she bears Phinehas. He grows up in the priestly family. <i>Exodus 6:25</i>
c. 1406 BC <i>Plains of Moab</i>	Stops the plague Israel joins in the worship of Baal-peor, and a plague spreads. When Zimri brings Cozbi, a Midianite, into his tent, Phinehas kills them both with a javelin. The plague stops after 24,000 have died. <i>Numbers 25:1-9, 14-15</i>
c. 1406 BC <i>Plains of Moab</i>	Given a covenant God says Phinehas has turned away his wrath. He gives him a covenant of peace and a lasting priesthood for his descendants. <i>Numbers 25:10-13</i>
c. 1406 BC <i>Midian</i>	Goes to war Moses sends Phinehas with the army against Midian, carrying the holy instruments and the trumpets. <i>Numbers 31:1-8</i>
After the conquest	Prevents a civil war The eastern tribes build a large altar by the Jordan. Phinehas leads a delegation, listens to their explanation, and brings back a report of peace. <i>Joshua 22:10-34</i>
Days of the judges	Serves before the ark In the war against Benjamin, Phinehas stands before the ark at Bethel (the KJV reads "the house of God") and asks the LORD whether Israel should fight. <i>Judges 20:26-28</i>

Key activities

Many readers today find Numbers 25 troubling. The text presents Phinehas's act as God's judgment in a unique crisis, and later Scripture praises it. Christians differ on how such passages should shape life under the new covenant, where believers are told not to take vengeance (Romans 12:19).

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- 1 **Acted when others stood still.** While the congregation wept, he rose up and acted. *Numbers 25:6-7*
 - 2 **Turned away God's wrath.** God said he had been "zealous for my sake" and had "made an atonement for the children of Israel." *Numbers 25:11-13*
 - 3 **Received a covenant of peace.** God promised him and his descendants an everlasting priesthood. *Numbers 25:12-13*
 - 4 **Went out with the army.** He carried the holy instruments and trumpets in the war against Midian. *Numbers 31:6*
 - 5 **Listened before judging.** He heard the eastern tribes explain their altar and said, "This day we perceive that the LORD is among us." *Joshua 22:30-31*
 - 6 **Gave his father a resting place.** Eleazar was buried in a hill that belonged to Phinehas in Ephraim. *Joshua 24:33*
 - 7 **Led in worship.** He served before the ark and sought God's guidance for Israel. *Judges 20:27-28*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Phinehas.

Old Testament

Exodus 6:25	His birth in Aaron's family
Numbers 25:1–18; 31:6	Peor, the covenant of peace, the war with Midian
Joshua 22:10–34	He settles the dispute over the altar by the Jordan
Judges 20:27–28	Priest before the ark
1 Chronicles 6:4, 50; Ezra 7:1–5	In the high priestly line to Zadok and Ezra
1 Chronicles 9:20	"The LORD was with him"
Psalms 106:30–31	"Counted unto him for righteousness"

New Testament

Echo: John 2:17	"The zeal of thine house hath eaten me up"
Echo: 1 Corinthians 10:8	Paul probably recalls Peor
Echo: Ephesians 2:14–17	Jesus the one who makes peace

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What were Moses and the people doing when Phinehas acted (Numbers 25:6–8)?
2. *Understand:* How do you understand Phinehas's zeal at Peor alongside his careful listening in Joshua 22?
3. *Apply:* Where do you see a slow drift into compromise? What firm step can you take against it?
4. *Apply:* Is there a conflict where you need to ask questions, as Phinehas did, before drawing conclusions?